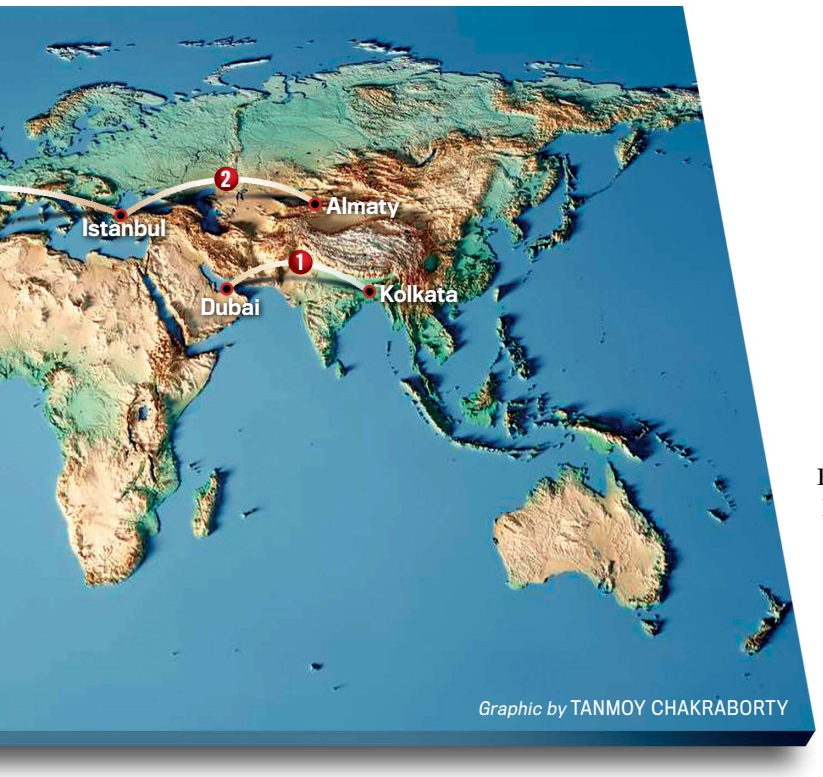
Eight flights, nine destinations, 100 days, travel by boat, car and mini truck–Deepak Boxer's run across the globe was a sensational escapade cut short



5 **Feb. 7** Port of Spain to Paramaribo, Suriname

6 **Feb. 28** Port of Spain to Panama City

7 **Feb. 28** Panama City to San Jose, Costa Rica

8 **Mar. 1** San Jose, to El Salvador

9 **Mar. 19** El Salvador to Mexico

DONKERS
They are the facilitators of trafficking operations in foreign lands–arranging documents, safe houses, transport. They are a vital cog for the smooth functioning of such rackets.

EXPLOITING LEGAL LOOPHOLES
Istanbul, Almaty, Panama City, Port of Spain...all the cities gangsters like Deepak–and other migrants–fly to en route to their destination offer visas on arrival. Once there, gangsters take refuge behind tough restrictions on extradition.

Guadalajara province. "It was a combination of 'tech intel' and human intelligence. We were tracking each and every move of Deepak Boxer... across continents and time zones, in coordination with the FBI and the Mexican police," Dhaliwal tells INDIA TODAY. The high-level decision—involving the Intelligence Bureau, RAW as well as the ministries of external and home affairs—to close in on Deepak started taking shape on March 19, when the police got reliable information of his presence in Mexico. Deepak would be brought back, it was decided, but not through the extradition route.

THE MOST DANGEROUS PART ON THE DONKEY ROUTE INVOLVES MOVING THROUGH THE JUNGLES OF PANAMA, FULL OF WILD ANIMALS AND THE DRUG MAFIA

The FBI had a favour to return too. In November 2022, FBI officials had sought, and received, the help of Delhi Police help in busting rackets of cyber criminals who were defrauding Americans. Though most of the technical and human intelligence to track Deepak down was done by special cell teams, for his physical capture, the FBI pressed into service its own agents on the ground, along with the Mexican police. "Though we were exchanging information with the FBI and the Mexican police, a time difference of around 12 hours between India and Mexico was delaying the operation. So, two members of the special cell—Inspector Gagan Bhaskar and his colleague, Inspector Manish Yadav—were sent to Mexico," Dhaliwal says. Subsequently, green, blue and red corner notices were issued by the CBI with the help of Interpol.

As part of Operation Mexico, the FBI, Mexican police and special cell teams electronically and physically shadowed Deepak for 10 days. Deepak last used his cellphone on March 24 in Cancun, and his locations were traced between Cancun, Merida and Tehuacan cities. On the night of March 31, Bhaskar and Yadav reached Mexico. While they were on their way, the FBI shared with Delhi a picture of a suspect detained at Cancun airport who was about to board a flight to the US. It was Deepak, caught in the nick of time. Inspectors Bhaskar and Yadav completed the legal formalities for Deepak's custody. Two Mexican police officers accompanied them for half the return journey to Delhi, up to Istanbul, before a second special cell team joined them. Operation Mexico was a success, but the fact that Deepak had nearly made his elaborate getaway showed it was a close-run thing.

While Deepak's motivation was to evade the law, the hapless thousands travelling on the donkey route to the US are driven by desperation of a different sort. While only a minuscule number get asylum, most are caught at the border and endure a hard existence in detention centres before being deported. Most run the gauntlet of ruthless drug mafia, traffickers, donkers and other grave perils of the journey. Undeterred, several try it again. All for an elusive foothold in a dreamland called America. ■